In the Kingdom of Fools

The big idea

This Kannada **folk tale** (retold by **A. K. Ramanujan**) is set in a kingdom where the king and minister are **idiots**. Night is day, everything costs the same, and justice is absurd. A wise **guru** saves his foolish **disciple** with a clever trick. It shows the value of **wisdom** and the danger of living in a foolish system for selfish gain.

The absurd rules

- People must **sleep during the day and work at night**; anyone caught working by day is punished.
- **Everything costs one duddu**: a measure of rice or a bunch of bananas, the same price.

Summary

1. A **guru and his disciple** arrive. Seeing that food is so cheap, the disciple wants to stay and grow fat. The guru warns that a kingdom of fools is dangerous and leaves, but the disciple stays.
2. A **thief** breaks into a **merchant's** house; an old **wall collapses** and kills him. His **brother** complains to the king.
3. The king summons the merchant, who blames the **bricklayer** who built the wall (in the merchant's father's time).
4. The bricklayer blames a **dancing girl** whose jingling anklets distracted him. She blames the **goldsmith**, who made her walk up and down by not finishing her jewellery. The goldsmith says he was busy with jewellery ordered by the **merchant's father**.

5. The king concludes the **merchant** is guilty (as his father's heir). A stake is prepared, but the merchant is **too thin** to be impaled properly. The king orders that a **fat man** be found instead. The servants find the **disciple**, who has grown fat on cheap food.
6. The disciple prays to his guru, who arrives. The guru whispers a plan. At the stake, the guru and disciple **argue about who should die first**. Asked why, the guru says the stake is "the stake of the god of justice": **whoever dies on it now will be reborn as the king** of this country, and the next will be reborn as the minister.
7. Not wanting to lose his throne in his next life, the **king** has himself and his **minister** impaled. The people then ask the guru and disciple to rule. The guru agrees on condition that the old laws are changed.

MORAL

Wisdom saves; greed traps. The disciple's greed for cheap food nearly killed him; the guru's presence of mind saved him and freed the kingdom from foolish rulers.

Characters

- **King and minister**: foolish, irrational, cruel in judgement.
- **Guru**: wise, far-sighted, quick-witted.
- **Disciple**: simple, greedy, but devoted to his guru.

Themes

- Wisdom versus foolishness; the importance of rational justice.
- Greed leads to danger.
- Humour and satire of absurd rulers.

ORDER OF BLAME

Merchant → bricklayer → dancing girl → goldsmith → merchant's father. Students often mix up the dancing girl and the goldsmith.

LIKELY QUESTIONS

What were the two strange things about the kingdom? Why did the guru not want to stay? How did he save his disciple? How did the king die?

Quick recap

- Night is day; everything costs one duddu.
- Absurd trial over the thief's death; merchant too thin, fat disciple chosen.
- Guru's trick: rebirth as king; foolish king and minister die.

Practice questions

1. In the Kingdom of Fools, everything cost

   (a) one duddu (b) two rupees (c) one paisa (d) nothing at all

2. Why did the disciple want to stay in the kingdom?

   (a) To become king (b) To learn their customs (c) Because food was cheap and plentiful (d) Because the guru asked him to

3. How did the thief die?

   (a) The merchant killed him (b) The king punished him (c) A wall of the merchant's house fell on him (d) He fell from a roof

4. Whom did the bricklayer blame?

   (a) The goldsmith (b) The merchant (c) The thief's brother (d) A dancing girl

5. Why was the disciple chosen for the stake?

   (a) He confessed to the crime (b) He was the thief's brother (c) He was fat enough for the stake (d) The guru betrayed him

6. How did the king die?

   (a) He was killed by the people (b) He fell ill (c) He had himself impaled to be reborn as king (d) He was poisoned by the minister

7. How did the guru save his disciple?

8. Why did the guru say the Kingdom of Fools was not a good place to live? Was he right?

Answers: 1. a 2. c 3. c 4. d 5. c 6. c 7. see notes 8. see notes